

OlivePad—the Indian connection from scratch

About 70 per cent of the work on OlivePad has happened in India. A team of 50 R&D professionals spent six months working on specifications development, testing, design, and software development for the OlivePad.

is what will win over the Indian market," says Kshitij Keote, vice-president, product engineering and technology, Olive Telecom. Let's take a quick look at the features.

Power of 3G

The OlivePad supports 3.5G HSPA, allowing users to stay connected even outside Wi-Fi hot-spots. "The 3G network access speeds are 7.2 MBps for downloads, and 5.6 MBps for uploads," says Keote.

Doubles up as a mobile phone

The device can also be used as a video/voice-call smartphone. "The OlivePad has a 3G SIM card slot, which allows it to be used as a super smartphone. Further, there is an autofocus 3 mega-pixel camera behind the tablet, and a VGA camera in front, making video calling easy. The two built-in speakers, coupled with the A2DP (stereo Bluetooth), and the device's compatibility with MPEG4 and 3GP file formats for video, makes it an ideal video-calling device," says Keote.

The strong backing of Android

Further, OlivePad operates on the Android 2.1 operating system. This being an open platform, it allowed Olive Telecom to provide users access to the entire Android applications marketplace, lowered cost barriers, and sped up product development. "Today, Android is an upcoming operating system, and most mobile device players are moving towards it. Besides, consumers (in India too) are getting more comfortable with the OS. Further, the OS was a perfect fit for our device, as it was built for touchscreen devices like the OlivePad," says Keote.

But has Android lived up to expectations? Yes, it has, says Keote.

"Time to market was a huge challenge, as we wanted the first-mover advantage. Android has helped a lot there, as it comes with a standard OS and an SDK that allowed us to customise it easily, resulting in faster time to market. The base Android OS was first customised on a lower level, wherein network parameters were preloaded, etc. Thereafter, there was a second level of customisation at the user interface level, which included market-specific applications," says Keote.



Arun Khanna, chairman,
Olive Telecom

Talking about market-specific applications, the Android Market gives the user access to 70,000

downloadable applications. Further, Olive Telecom is moving fast on its own. "OlivePad is working on embedding a map application, apart from Google Maps, for which one needs data connectivity. This application, developed by Map My India, allows the user to get the most minute details, like turn-by-turn directions. Further, we are working on the specifications of a Web-based application that would allow people to watch good-quality live TV on our 17+ cm device. We are still in talks with vendors, and will be embedding this application in our product soon," says Keote. Some of these embedded applications will be free, while some will be paid for. "The map application is free, and we hope to offer free service for the mobile TV application for the first three to six months. Thereafter, it will be a paid service," says Keote.

But, are one or two applications

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